fragmentation of holdings has increased the number of holdings, obviously of smaller size. According to the results of Agriculture Census 1990–91:

- The total number of operational holdings in the country had increased from 972 million in 1985–86 to 1066 million in 1985–86 to 1066 million in 1990–91.
- Operated area, on the other hand, had risen only marginally, i.e., by about 0.6 per cent. Rise in the number of holdings without corresponding increase in area clearly showed pressure of population on land with average size of holding declining from 1.69 hectare in 1985–86 to 1.55 hectare in 1990–91. 59 per cent of total operational holdings in 1990–91 were of size less than 1 hectare (i.e., marginal holdings), 32.2 per cent of size between 1–4 hectare (i.e., small holdings), 7.2 per cent of size between 4–10 hectares (i.e., medium holdings) and only 1.6 per cent of size more than 10 hectares (i.e., large holdings).
- In 1985–86, Rajasthan had the highest average holding size of 4.34 hectares, followed by Punjab having an average size of 3.77 hectares. Contrary to it, Kerala was having the lowest average holding size of 0.36 hectares (1985–86 data are the latest.) Agricultural holdings have been classified into ***three*** categories:

1. Economic Holding

It is that holding which ensures a minimum satisfactory standard of living to a family. In other words, economic holding is a minimum essential area for profitable agriculture.

2. Family Holding

Family holding is that holding which gives work to average size family having one plough under traditional farming system. In other words, family holding is a ***'plough unit'*** which is neither less nor more for an average size family to cultivate it properly.

3. Optimum Holding